

A Methodist Guide for Christian Conduct in the 21st Century, Malaysia

(Based on the General Rules of the Methodist Church in Malaysia)

The Methodist Society first began and spread in 1739 when John Wesley counselled some people who sought him for their spiritual needs. Wesley defined the Society's purpose as: a community of people seeking to be godly, praying for one another, encouraging one another, and watching over one another in love so as to help each other work out their salvation.

Furthermore, to ensure that they were indeed working out their own salvation, each society was divided into classes of about twelve persons with a leader in each class. The leader was to facilitate accountability for the members and to encourage them according to their needs.

The condition in joining the Methodist Society then was: a desire to avoid God's judgment and to seek to overcome their sins. When such a condition was met, it was expected of them that their lives will evidence it by keeping the General Rules laid down for them.

Just as Wesley gave the General Rules to the members of the Methodist Society in his day to help them live out their Christian faith, so The Methodist Church in Malaysia provides this Guide to our Methodist members today to help them conduct their lives appropriate to their Christian faith. The Guide is designed bearing in mind today's culture.

To help our members live up to their Christian conduct, they are encouraged to participate in the Small Groups in our Methodist churches. The Small Groups in our Methodist churches are set up with the special emphasis of accountability.

Methodist members are to observe this Guide; they are expected to keep away from the sinful way of life and to cultivate a godly way of life. Those who are determined to live such a life will abide by the Guide that includes:

First, by not doing wrong, and intentionally avoiding all kinds of evil conduct. Such conducts include the following:

Criminal Conducts

- Being abusive sexually, physically and verbally on account of our position and advantage at home, at work, and elsewhere.
- Involving in gangsterism, human trafficking, prostitution, drug trafficking, and terrorism.
- Involving in corruption, illegal trading, smuggling, buying and selling goods that have not paid the duty, and unfair pricing.
- Taking advantage of and mistreating the foreigners: domestic maids, foreign laborers, and refugees.

Social Misconducts

- Misusing the name of God in swearing, exclaiming, and rebuking in our speech.
- Extorting or charging high interest when lending money. Borrowing money with the intention of not paying back or with doubtful ability to pay back.
- Spreading rumors, unverified news, and hate comments in daily conversation or via the media such as sms, emails, blogs, facebook, twitter, etc.
- Fighting, brawling, quarreling, gossiping, being vengeful, and taking fellow believers to court.
- Making unnecessary provocative or insensitive remarks that increase ethnic tension, religious conflict, and political unrest.
- Involving in homosexual, lesbian and bi-sexual practices and their advocacy.
- Involving in fornication, adultery, incest, pedophilia, bestiality, and other forms of unnatural sex.

Personal Misconducts

- Not observing the day of the Lord as the day of community worship and rest.
- Smoking, getting drunk, and being addicted to illegal drugs.

- Doing things that violate godliness and holiness, such as:
 - o Putting on clothes that are too revealing, and not in keeping with dressing modestly and in good taste.
 - o Singing immoral songs that promote sex outside marriage, drugs, and negative behaviors.
 - o Reading and viewing of pornographic materials.
 - o Indulging in food, internet, relationships, work, pleasures, etc. to the degree that they become addictive and impede normal healthy social relationships.
 - o Hoarding of time, money and talents in pursuit of a selfish and materialistic life style.

All Methodists ought to show the seriousness of living out their faith in Christ by the manner in which they conduct themselves.

Second: By doing good works. They are to take every opportunity according to their ability and as far as they can to help all those who are in need.

They do so, first, by attending to the social and physical needs of the homeless, the hungry, the abused, the sick, the bereaved, the lonely, the physically challenged, the aged, the refugees, the imprisoned, etc.

They do so, second, by attending to the spiritual needs by teaching, correcting and encouraging all with whom they come into contact. This is to be done in love and without fear or delay since it is still their responsibility irrespective of how they feel about it.

Their priority of doing good works begins with those within the family of God. Whenever possible, they give employment to and engage in business dealings with believers. They should not expect such help to come from those outside the church, for the world only looks after its own.

They are to do good works diligently and with good stewardship so that the witness to the Gospel will be seen.

In their calling to do good works, they are to persevere in fulfilling it, and be willing to suffer and make sacrifices for it. When faced with false accusations and treated in derogatory manner, they are to press on for the sake of the Lord.

All Methodists ought to show the seriousness of living out their faith in Christ by the manner in which they conduct themselves.

Third, by participating in the spiritual disciplines such as:

- Community worship and Holy Communion in Church.
- Small Groups.
- Bible studies.
- Personal devotion.
- Family devotion.
- Fasting.

These guidelines are conduct expected of every Methodist member. They are conducts consistent with the exhortations from the Scripture, and the Holy Spirit bears witness to these exhortations in the hearts of those who are truly born again.

It is their responsibility as fellow members of the Methodist Church to encourage each other to observe the conducts spelled out in this Guide. It is also their responsibility to warn their fellow members who consistently break the guidelines. When such behaviors are deemed to require further action, Church leaders will take the necessary steps.